

KORANTINE RITES

Designing a quasi-ancient society for Mythras and other RPGs

by Jonathan Drake

Part III: Cities and City-States

This is the point in our journey where a trackway through open country has brought us to the gates of an impressive walled city. Rising above the walls we can see high ground crowned with fine pillared buildings we can take to be temples. We imagine that, hidden from our view behind the walls, all around this acropolis are streets and plazas humming with activity as the city's thousands of inhabitants go about their daily lives. But as we take in the view it does look very much as if these city folk have little interest in what is happening outside their walls. And perhaps they can be forgiven because by the look of things not very much is happening at all...

CITY STATES

A quasi-ancient world contains many cities, and every one of them, no matter how small, is a sovereign state. A city isn't defined by just walls, houses, monuments and borders, but by its people. When a city acts it is the people acting together, not an abstract. The Athenians, not Athens, the Meerish, not Meeros, the

Himelans, not Korantine Himela, go to war, or honour the gods, or make a treaty with a foreign power. The ideal city-state is economically self-sufficient and politically independent. Neither an individual citizen nor the city itself can be truly free if it is somehow dependent on others for sustenance and survival. To safeguard this self-sufficiency and self-determination the citizenry are all ready and willing, and expected, to step up and defend their land and their city from raiders and invaders. Nevertheless some cities are very small and are situated uncomfortably close to a much bigger city, a powerful 'barbarian' people, or the frontiers of a foreign empire. These cities quickly find themselves needing to make accommodation with their neighbours – or find a more powerful protector.

Origin Stories

Some cities have grown up gradually and organically from a single village or settlement, some are the result of a deliberate act of



foundation at a specific point in time by settlers and colonists. Many have been created when a bunch of connected villages and towns decide (or are forced) to combine, and choose a place to now be their shared religious, political and economic centre, a process known as *synoikism* – literally, making home together. Enough cities owe their origins to some kind of founding event, in which a group of people decide to build a new community together, that the idea of a social contract between its citizens – a constitution, and nearly always a *republican* constitution – becomes the accepted way to organise things. Monarchies get consigned to history, the few that exist are thought of as ‘survivals’, although that doesn’t stop ambitious individuals trying to reinvent the idea on a regular basis.

How Big Is the City?

A city-state can come in many shapes and sizes. To start with we need to think about its population. At the bottom end, it must be big enough to be capable of fielding a credible force for self-defence. But this can be just a few hundred warriors, requiring a total population

of perhaps 2,000 - about right for a recently founded colony or small island state. There is no upper limit, however the available land around each city will limit its growth, and once the capacity of its territory is exceeded it can grow no more unless it can ship in food from elsewhere or simply take new land from other people. A typical ancient city in the classical era was probably home to no more than about 5,000 people. Anything over 25,000 would entitle a city to feel pretty important, and anything over 100,000 would denote a rare metropolis¹. The biggest city in a quasi-ancient world, capital of a world-spanning Empire, might contain a million people!

A city’s physical extent can be defined by tracing the line of the city walls, which are built to encompass all of the key structures, public spaces and residential suburbs. There are examples of cities without walls, but they are unusual. The Spartans boasted they had no need for city walls because they need only trust in the valour and prowess of their citizen-warriors for their security. A typical ‘intramural’ area (the space enclosed by city walls) is 100-150 hectares. As cities get bigger walls are

¹ Used here in the modern sense to denote a very big city, but the origin of the word is ancient, and means ‘mother city’ in the specific sense of one

that has sent out colonies that have grown into cities in their own right



extended, and usually population density gets higher as one-story houses arranged around courtyards and gardens give way to multi-story, multi-functional buildings and tenement blocks. Sometimes the walls enclose a lot of open space, so you can get a city with a big footprint without necessarily having a much bigger population. A Metropolis of 100,000 or more people may have a walled area of a 1,000 hectares (10 square kilometers), while an Imperial Megacity may simply burst out from the area protected by its walls spilling out over the surrounding landscape, waiting for decades, or even centuries, for someone comes along to build a new set of walls to match its new size – the Aurelian Walls of Rome and the Theodosian Walls of Constantinople both enclosed areas of over 1300 hectares!

What's in a City?

The walled city is above all a place to live. However to be the base of a functioning city-state it also needs public places where the inhabitants can gather and all kinds of public business can be done – an *agora* or a *forum*. This can be no more than an open piece of ground, but it usually evolves into a big, paved plaza surrounded by important buildings, shady pillared walkways, adorned with monuments and public inscriptions carved into stone so as

many people can see and refer to them as possible. The city's key temples are usually close by too. These are probably the largest and most splendid buildings in the city, and it is not unusual that if the city has an additional fortified area at its heart (an acropolis) those fortifications are specially planned to embrace the temples to the city's favourite 'tutelary' deity. Somewhere there must be another open space or some kind of public hall – for the council to meet, and for legal cases to be heard. The council might be elected, chosen by lottery, a council of elders or a council of the heads of the most prominent families, or some combination of all of them – every city has its own system. Important priests of the city's gods may have seats on the council, or be called upon as advisors. The chief officers of state might operate from their private houses – however the principle is that all formal public business is done in public view.

Most cities have places where people gather for entertainment – anything from a hippodrome for chariot races to theatres, or an amphitheatre (basically two semi-circular theatres joined together, *amphi-* meaning 'on both sides'). With the exception of the most famous amphitheatre of all, the Coliseum, these buildings tend to be on the outskirts of a city,

possibly even outside the walls. Cemeteries are also almost always outside the walls – only very special people who are being memorialised get to be buried within the city limits. So the roads approaching the city are often lined with tombs and tombstones.

The Domain

For a time the famous city of Athens was a little bit like the fantasy city that has no visible means of support from the landscape around it. Towards the end of the 5th Century BC Athens and Sparta spent nearly 30 years at war, and in that time the Spartans exploited their superiority on land to occupy or lay waste to large parts of the country around Athens itself. Thousands of countryfolk found themselves cooped up inside the city walls, and inevitably in these cramped conditions a deadly plague broke out. But Athens survived, largely by shipping in the food it needed to her harbours, and these harbours were connected to the city itself by the famous ‘long walls’ built in anticipation of just such a situation. But Athens was exceptional in many ways – with access to large stocks of cash, naval superiority, and

plenty of overseas possessions and connections stretching as far away as Black Sea to bring whatever it needed. Most ancient cities placed in the same situation would eventually (and possibly quickly) be starved into submission. Which is why, as we make our way to the gates of a fantasy city, we should imagine ourselves travelling through a landscape that’s full of crops and pasture, olive groves and orchards, farms, villages, homesteads and villas. In reality the city in a quasi-ancient world is just the nucleus of a heavily exploited landscape around it that we will call its *domain*². A city’s territory is its most vital resource because it provides food for its people. It is quite common to deny the right to own land to anyone who is not a local citizen, and to deny the full rights of citizenship to those who don’t have any. It can be a high honour to make an exception to the rule for a foreigner.³

When the city is founded its domain, or at least what it claims to be its domain and is able to patrol or defend, may still include lots of open country. Unless it comes already equipped with a subject population of serves or slaves to bring it into production this land can await the arrival



² The ancient Greek term is *chora*, the ‘ch’ pronounced as in ‘choir’

³ Naturally, if the foreigner is a citizen of a conquering empire, all the rules can be relaxed...

of more settlers or the gradual expansion of the citizenry through natural growth. As population grows over time then the open country will gradually be ploughed, cleared or otherwise put to use, except for the parts that are too rocky, mountainous or marshy. But wetlands can be drained, mountains can be quarried for stone, provide all-important timber, or at least wild land for hunting. The most inaccessible parts perhaps keep an aura of sanctity, left for the gods and spirits to roam undisturbed, and for people to visit only as part of some cult rituals or rite of passage. If a population continues to grow then at some point it will hit the limits of what the domain can support⁴.

If there are especially useful mineral resources in the domain they are likely to be controlled by the city authorities. Mines are very important, especially silver and gold mines. This collective ownership may also extend to natural resources like migrating wildlife. Look-outs might be posted to watch not just for sea-borne invaders but for a big shoal of tuna or sardines, or a school of dolphins or whales when the right season comes around, and the whole community mobilises to catch, kill and process the bonanza on a scale that adds to everyone's prosperity. Some land may be collective – the title held by city or by one of its parts (like a local district or village) or even by a temple. This land is usually leased out to farmers to exploit and pay over a tithe of their produce (assume somewhere between 5% and 15%). But as the city and its people and the land are all so tightly connected by tradition as well as law, the interests of the state can override private ownership when it comes to land holdings – lands can be confiscated from citizens and placed into public ownership as well as allocated to citizens in need or who have served their city well.

Estimating the Size of a Domain

If you are designing a quasi-ancient society for your setting and you are populating a fantasy

landscape with cities, then how many should there be, and how far apart? A good way to get a realistic idea of the possible density of cities across the map is to take a view on how large the domain of each should be. To find some answers to that I am using an abstraction, which is to look at typical city sizes from real-world antiquity against the amount of land required to feed their estimated population.

So how big does a domain need to be to ensure self-sufficiency? For a start it rather depends on how much of that land is suitable for growing food crops rather than being rocky hills, forests, mountains, marshes, deserts and the like. Looking at some of the assumptions made by modern historians on the classical world, a figure of 30% of the land being suitable for staple food crops is a reasonable baseline. Some cities will enjoy dominance over a broad plain or plateau where it is possible to put a much higher proportion of land under crops, others will be nestled in rocky hill-country, growing food on artificial terraces or in little valleys among the hills, or hemmed in by a mountain range to a small plain bordering the sea,

To arrive at some rough figures, if we were to assume that the overwhelming calorie intake of a city's population is made up of grain products like wheat and barley, and that those have a calorific value of about 3,400 kcal per kilo, we need to produce something in the region of 240kg of grain or equivalent every year to feed each inhabitant. A Hectare of land can produce perhaps 700kg using a yield of 6x the seed corn planted. Allowing for some of the harvest to be set aside as seed corn for the following year, providing all the calories needed by a city of 5,000 people requires the harvest of about 1,800 Hectares. Allowing for crop rotation or fallowing, that means a total of perhaps 3,600 Hectares of arable land. That means you would expect a self-sufficient city to command a total domain of about three times that, something

⁴ Usually referred to as its *carrying capacity*

over 100 square kilometres, per 5,000 population.

The City Size Table

The City Size Table is a starting point from which you can scale up or down according to the specific geography of your setting. If a city does not have access to this much land, or is situated in a region where the land surface is dominated by desert, steep hills, mountains, forest or water, then perhaps there is some

setting-specific or magical reason that enables it to thrive. If not, then it is probably importing food from elsewhere. But the answer may lie in the 60-70% of the land that isn't suitable for staple food production. It may offer up timber, minerals and precious metals, ground suitable for vineyards, pasture, lakes, rivers and shores for fish. Perhaps the people themselves hire out at mercenaries in agricultural downtime, or practise piracy and raiding on a big enough scale to fill the gaps in the city's economy.

CITY SIZE TABLE					
<i>City Size</i>	<i>Total City-State Population</i>	<i>Urban Footprint</i>	<i>Domain Area</i>	<i>Approximate Territory Diameter</i>	<i>Notes</i>
Small	1,000-3,000	25-50 Hectares	50 sq km	8km	Almost all the people live in the city itself, farmers commute out to their fields each day.
Medium	4,000-6,000	50-100 Hectares	100 sq km	12km	More than two thirds of people live in the city, there may be a few large estates and farmsteads dotted around the territory and perhaps small villages, hamlets and shepherds' huts in its outer reaches
Large	10,000-20,000	100-200 Hectares	300 sq km	20km	More than half the people live in the city, but there are outlying villages and one or two small towns
Very Large	30,000-50,000	200-500 Hectares	500 sq km	25km	Less than half the people live in the city, the rest in outlying towns and villages who come to the city for important markets, festivals, to access the law or attend political meetings.
Metropolis	100,000-250,000	500-1,000 Hectares	3,000 sq km	60km	Less than a third of people live in the city, which has the character of a capital commanding several towns and many villages across its territory
Imperial Megacity	5,000,000 - 10,000,000	1,000+ Hectares	150,000 sq km	450km	No more than 10% of the people live in the city but are supported by the labour of vast numbers of people across a huge area.

Landscape doesn't come in nice geometric shapes and divisions, but thinking about it in this way gives you an idea of how to visualise the extent of territory a city in your setting might command. All the figures here have been rounded and approximated. A city could be on the edge of its territory, so the diameter across its lands is perhaps a better guide than the radius, providing the maximum distance you are likely to have to travel through a territory before you reach the city at its core. For the inhabitants, the size of the territory plays a part in whether they can live within the confines of the city and yet reach their fields and farms in walking distance of the city gates, or whether it becomes necessary for some whose business is further afield to make their home in an outlying village, farmstead or villa.

Expanding the Domain

Some cities simply can't live off what can be produced from their domains, and don't have rich silver mines, like Athens did, to fund the shortfall. Expansion of the domain into virgin territory is rarely an option. They could be limited by natural barriers like rivers or mountains, entirely bordered by rival states or tribes, or simply occupying an island with a finite amount of space. Some manage to get by off the profits of maritime trade, but that strategy has severe limits when you don't or can't produce much of anything yourself and are limited to being a middleman. Most are just forced to stay small – which, if you don't keep birth rates under control, eventually involves sending excess people out on colonising missions. And if you can't find territory to colonise then there is conquest: go and take the land and resources you need from someone else without their permission.

In a war of conquest everyone hopes to profit from the success. For this very reason the ordinary people who had to fill the ranks of a

citizen army regularly voted in favour of wars - in many places and times a declaration of war was the only decision in which the citizenry as a whole had the final say through an open vote. They might not only get a little pay and booty, but perhaps also the award of a much bigger parcel of land. If that results in farm a plot too big to exploit with just the labour of the farmer and his immediate family the original owners are subjected to them as tenants, or else prisoners of war subjected to slavery and put to work.

Growing the Population

There are also times when a city has to find ways to quickly increase its population. The effects of plague or of war, or just the desire to grow more quickly than fertility and mortality rates allow, means that unusual measures are called for. These can include allowing a large group of migrants the right to settle and receive full citizen rights (like when the Claudian family, originally Sabines, settled in Rome with their armed retainers), or to set free slaves and enfranchise them (as when the Thespians needed to rebuild their numbers after the losses suffered fighting alongside Leonidas and his 300 Spartans at Thermopylai)⁵. In the later eras described in Part I, it is common for new foundations to be quickly populated by incentivising people to come and settle or by issuing a royal or imperial edict forcing them to do so. This is how megacities come into being in a mere generation or two.

Raising Taxes

In an ancient economy taxes are not, after all, a certainty of life. There is generally no such thing as an income tax, and often no direct taxation of a state's citizens at all. Levying direct taxes is something that smacks of despotism, foreign kings and abuse of power, but it is quite possible resident foreigners are

alone former slaves. In the Roman world admitting outsiders to the citizenship is common and often done en masse.

⁵ As a rule of thumb, Greek-style cities are loathe to allow foreign settlers to join their citizenry, let

subject to a poll tax. Foreign possessions are a different case, and empires can bring dividends. Foreign subjects have their land and property assessed for tax – typically at 1% of value, and the money is collected either by their own local authorities and handed over as tribute, or collected by a private firm of 'tax farmers'. These people bid money for the right to collect tax in a given region or city and make a margin on the difference between what they bid and the amount actually raise.

The most common taxes are on trade - the state raises money from duties on both import and export, at a typical rate of 5%. Any goods not declared to port officials are liable for confiscation. A Sales Tax is common, the percentages applied normally quite low – perhaps as low as 0.5% and no higher than 3%. A farmer selling his own produce might be exempt – this is really there to catch traders who buy from one person to sell to another at a mark-up without having actually produced anything.

A major resource – such as a salt works or silver mine - would be heavily taxed, if not actually taken over by the state and exploited directly. The richest silver mines in the ancient world might yield millions of Silver Pieces in value every year. A democratic state might actually recognise this as common property, and use the silver to distribute money to its citizens. Or perhaps hold a public vote on whether to spend the money on war, ship-building, or public works.

A one-off property or wealth tax can be ordered from time to time to raise funds from the citizenry to meet a crisis (particularly in war), but when the crisis has passed there may even be efforts to repay the money - showing it is a sort of unsecured, obligatory loan to the state rather than a tax.

⁶ A 'tribe' is not necessarily some ancient lineage, but may have been recently instituted or updated

THE PEOPLE

Somewhere between 50% and 90% of all adults are working in agriculture. Those who have enough land to support themselves by good honest farming work are idealised as the backbone of the community – even if they are in the minority. Self-sufficient, they are not beholden to anyone else for a living, and as propertied people they have a vested interest in defending the state – and the status quo.

In a quasi-ancient society, Social Class can mean much more than just the lifestyle you can afford. It is something formally assessed by some kind of census. Your wealth, or income, or the land you hold, or some other measure appropriate to a fantasy setting, is assessed and you are assigned to a Social Class, and with that comes a set of political rights and privileges (or lack of) such as the right to vote, how much your vote counts, to serve as a juror or councillor, or to stand for election to public office. These political rights and privileges have a set of duties and obligations to go with them, and for most citizens that means the requirement to serve in some capacity in the city's armed forces when needed. Some cities can have a lot of different grades, or classes, of citizens, so the broad categories provided on the Quasi-Ancient Social Class table can be sliced into many more subdivisions if the city authorities or the Games Master ever feel the need!

The Household

A city-state is made up not just of citizens but of households. Every household has a nuclear family at its core but, depending on how wealthy it is, the household can include land and other property, goods and chattel including slaves and livestock, businesses and industrial interests. It probably also has some important intangibles – like membership of a specific 'tribe' within the citizen body⁶, perhaps the

to divide the citizenry into appropriate size units for things like voting blocs and forming militia units

right to live in certain places in the city or its surrounding territory, eligibility for certain cults, rites or priesthoods. The head of the household is the only one who really has a role in the public life of the city, and the city authorities and lawmakers usually have very limited reach into the private sphere of the household. At the extreme, this means the head of the household has power of life or death over everyone in it – over their own freeborn sons and daughters just as much as over the family slaves, and the state has no right to overrule or intervene.

Age Classes

Alongside divisions of the people by wealth are divisions by age category. These can be ritually

formalised, or just general rules about who does what. The reasons are usually connected in some way with military service. The youth (typically young adults aged 17 or 18 up to 20) get military training. They and older men (typically mid-40s and over) are usually designated for home defence rather than marching out to war. But age can be important in other ways too, for example expecting men to wait until they are somewhat older and ready to lead a household before they marry. It's worth remembering that all ancient societies are constructed not around the individual so much as round the household, and the head of the household (usually but not always a man) controls everyone and everything in it. Even adult children may have no property to call their own until their father dies and his estate is

QUASI-ANCIENT SOCIAL CLASS TABLE				
D100	Social Class	Lifestyle (See Korantine Rites Pt II)	Possible Titles or Labels	Typical Landholding (Hectares)
01-05	Outcast	Pauper	Bandit, Robber, Runaway Slave, Exile, Fugitive, Cursed.	None
06-15	Chattel Slave	Pauper	Slave	None
16-25	Unfree labour, Serf	Pauper	Penestes, Helot, Colonus, Serf, Debt Bondsman	None
26-50	The Free Poor	Poor Townsman or Subsistence Farmer	Freeman, Thes, Peasant, Proletarian, Headcount, Tenant Farmer, Labourer	0-2
51-55	Resident Alien, Free non-citizen	Yeoman Farmer or Artisan	Foreigner, Free Non-citizen, Metic, Artisan, Perioikos,	None
56-85	Yeoman	Yeoman Farmer or Artisan	Farmer, Artisan, Hoplite	5-8
86-95	Gentry	Affluent Merchant, Business Owner or Landowner	Farmer, Hoplite	15-20
96-99	Rich	Rich Estate Owner	Hippeis, Eques, Knight, Horseman	50-100
00	Aristocrat, Magnate	Aristocrat or Land Magnate	King, Tyrant, Senator, Archon, Basileus, General, Patrician	250-500

passed on. There can also be laws that put a minimum age on holding public office – for example, until the system fell apart because the rules were routinely broken, the minimum age to serve as a consul of Rome was 42.

Outcasts

People who are outside society, and outside the protection of the law. They can be fugitives, runaway slaves, people who have already taken to crime and banditry because that is all that is left for them; they could be people deemed ritually cursed and tainted, expelled from civilisation and the protection of hearth, home, family and community; they may carry a physical or mental illness that people regard as dangerous or contagious and for which they are shunned.

Overall an outcast from one city or community may find safe harbour in another. If people come looking for them, for example for a runaway slave, then their fate may rest on what relations there are between a city where they seek sanctuary and the one they have fled.

Chattel Slaves

In the ancient world slavery is everywhere. Sometimes enslaved people are found only in the houses of the rich as domestic servants, or perhaps tending their livestock. But there are certain times and/or places where slave labour becomes a huge proportion of the work force and becomes essential to how the economy operates.

When the poor are freed from dependency, the rich often look to slave labour to fix their need for labour. Becoming enslaved is a potential hazard for anyone. Raiders and pirates take people to sell as slaves, invading armies take slaves in their thousands and are followed around by slave traders who can convert human booty into hard cash and pass them into the growing trading network. International trading networks are established to traffic the slaves to where there is demand for labour. Slaves can be

state-owned, but most are owned by individuals, whether that's a farmer or artisan who has a skilled slave to work alongside them day to day, a brothel-keeper looking to staff their premises or a rich magnate with hundreds of slaves at work on their estates or tending their flocks, and dozens more in their palatial city residences. In some places (Classical Athens is the best known example) even the police force are slaves. People who have the money to acquire slaves do so because it either grows their business or allows them to retreat into a life of leisure while someone else does the work with labour that is totally at their command.

The life of a slave can range from a brutal and short existence toiling down a mine under terrible conditions to - for a very, very few - enjoying a luxury lifestyle managing estates and businesses for their owner with dozens of people at their command and wielding considerable influence. What they have in common is that they have no rights of any kind, no protection under the law. They may have benign owners with whom they have a genuine empathetic relationship, but that's the luck of the draw. They may be slave to a brute, or someone with no qualms about having slaves beaten, mutilated or killed when the mood takes them. Slave owners are entitled to do anything they want with their own property. Even so, slave revolts are surprisingly rare – or perhaps not surprisingly, given what's at stake. A failed slave revolt results in a horrible and humiliating death for all involved.

Nobody in the real ancient world challenged the institution of slavery, but some did attempt to justify it, either by suggesting that foreigners are naturally inclined to adopt the subservient role of a slave so are fair game, or that slaves are people who would otherwise have perished (e.g. been killed instead of taken prisoner in war) so it is a condition that is at least better than being dead. Ex-slaves cheerfully acquired slaves of their own. Roman slaves had a reasonable chance of being freed at some point in their lives, and while 'freedmen' still owed

service and loyalty to their former owner, their children enjoyed full independent rights of citizenship. If a significant proportion of the population are people who have been enslaved or born into slavery, a very large proportion of the free may have slaves in their ancestry.

Serfs

People we label as *serfs* are usually associated with the Medieval world, but similar institutions existed in antiquity, on a regional or local level, usually a result of a population subjugated by conquest. Most famous of all are *Helots*. These people are subject populations of the Spartans. They are definitely not free, but nor are they chattel slaves. They are not deracinated like most enslaved people but live in their own communities on the lands once inhabited by their free ancestors. They have family lives, their own religious cults, and perhaps informal institutions. They are not bought and sold on the slave markets, but they are tied to the land, which was once their land, now divided up and allocated to individual Spartan overlords for their upkeep. This makes it possible for the Spartans not to have to do any farming for themselves and devote themselves to service of the state. Sometimes helots are even called up to fight alongside the Spartans to make up numbers in battle, but if they show too much promise they are as likely to be murdered than rewarded, because the Spartans live in constant fear of Helot rebellion. Other populations find themselves in similar situation, such as the *Penestai* in Thessaly. But in history it remains unusual until, in the later Roman Empire, new kind of serfdom begins to replace slavery as the preferred source of unfree labour.

Debt Bondsmen

In Archaic stage cities free people can wind up in bondage by getting into debt. Tenant farmers pay a proportion of their produce to the landowner as rent – or a fixed lease. But the problem is that what's left may not be enough for the tenant and his family to survive on.

Clearly there are many who have small or unproductive plots, or just have a bad year and can't hand over the required share of their produce without going critically short themselves. With no property of their own the only thing they have on which they could secure the debt is their own bodies – so inevitably many fall into slavery as “debt-bondsman”. This is perfectly legal in many places. But if it happens too often the effect is simmering unrest, violence and civil strife. The aim of the protesters is usually the cancellation of debts that hold them in thrall to the rich and a redistribution of land to free them from falling into dependency again. At some point debt bondage is gets banned to resolve increasing tensions between rich and poor. In democratic cities, the amount that can be charged for a lease might also get capped (at 10% or less of the tenant's produce). Even so if a tenant farmer is in arrears with their rent the landlord can usually force them to stay put at the end of a contract until they have made it good.

The Free Poor

Historically some 65% of people lived in an economic state we would consider poor in absolute terms – meaning that they live with continual uncertainty about how they will survive year by year. Many are kept in poverty by their status as slaves, serfs or outcasts. But some are free citizens of their city, who all the same live in near destitution, or depend on handouts from others. Our fantasy world is likely to be no different unless the magical and fantasy elements have come together to abolish poverty.

The poorest citizens have little or no land of their own to exploit, or are perhaps too young, too old and/or infirm, to use or sell their labour. If they are able to offer up the strength of their bodies in return for pay, much of the time nobody is buying. A lean-to, shack or hovel may be the pauper's only shelter, and for clothes they have only rags cast off by someone

else. People living in such dire straits are a minority, but they are enough to be visible. Whenever drought, famine or war strike significant numbers of people are easily tipped into the same boat and driven to extreme behaviours such as infanticide (to reduce the number of dependent mouths), selling themselves or their children into slavery, prostitution, begging or taking up crime.

Out in the countryside you may be able to find a landlord who will rent you a piece of land with no downpayment, taking a share of the produce instead. Tenant leases may be for as short a period as one year, but are more usually for five or ten years. In any event these relationships rarely stop at an arm's length commercial deal. There are expectations of loyalty, deference, political support – a tenant can easily find himself a henchman.

A city might start introducing state hand-outs, payments for construction work, civic or military service and the like, by which the poor can be given a leg-up without owing anything to a rich benefactor. The only long-term way to lift people out of poverty is to resettle them on land commandeered from the rich (who may stage a coup d'état if you try), or commandeering land from other people by sending out a colony, or making war on other cities. For this reason the poor are often quite enthusiastic about using their vote to support a declaration of war, even though they are the ones who will have to go and fight it.

The poor are usually unable to provide themselves with military equipment to serve in the militia, so their role, if any, when the city musters its citizens for war is perhaps to serve as rowers in the navy or as light armed skirmishers in the land army. But as time goes on and cities or their new imperial overlords need people willing to take their silver and join an army that will spend long periods away from

home, they can find plenty of recruits among the poor if they are also able to provide the basic equipment they need. .

Resident Aliens

These are free people who choose to come to the city to live and work but are not citizens, and never likely to be. They have some protections under the law, but usually cannot own property, or marry a citizen. They may be subject to a poll tax, and they are expected to fight alongside their citizen neighbours in the militia. Despite the drawbacks the attractions for finding a ready market for their skills draws many itinerants to the bigger cities. They are often craftsmen or other specialists and may be quite affluent. For those who cannot stretch to renting a house of their own, cities with a lot of resident aliens tend to have tenement blocks where they can rent rooms or apartments. If they stay put for long enough to raise children of their own in their adoptive home, those children still keep their parents' 'resident alien' status and do not automatically become citizens.

The Yeomanry

While shamelessly borrowing a medieval term for a quasi-ancient setting, the idea of a yeoman is recognisable and appropriate – a farmer and landowner with enough means to be financially independent⁷. These people usually form the core, and the majority, of the citizen assembly and make up the bulk of the phalanx, or legion, of citizen militiamen. They work their own farm with the help of family members, and perhaps some casual labour brought in at busy times. Perhaps the most affluent of them have a slave or two working alongside the family. It is likely at least some of the family have had basic schooling and are literate, but highly unlikely they have access to literature, using their literacy in the public sphere to read official inscriptions and to mark their name. They and

⁷ There are many definitions of 'yeoman' depending on where and when we are talking

about, but the simple one used here is easily understood

their neighbours probably share resources like ploughs and oxen, and cooperate in (or at times get into disputes about) shaping the land in ways that will impact the whole community. Their farms will never make them rich, but if well managed, making clever use of their land, and with income supplemented by the women of the house doing work such as spinning and weaving, they can support a family quite well. They have a vested interest in the city's fortunes, and the status quo.

The Gentry

In ancient Sparta, every citizen belonged to the gentry. This was thanks to a much larger population of conquered and oppressed people, who were forced to work the land for Spartan overlords who as a result never had to worry about money and could spend their time hanging out with the guys and training up their martial skills – so they could put down any rebellions. But in most places the gentry are a small but important part of the citizen body – idealised because they still get their hands dirty working the farm, but not too dirty; they likely have tenants or slaves that do a lot of the heavy lifting, allowing them to pay attention to civic duties and a moderate amount of leisure pursuits. They are well enough off to equip themselves with decent armour and weapons to fight for their city, so will end up in the front ranks of the phalanx. But not so rich to have a horse and ride to war like the properly rich and the aristocrats. If the yeoman farmers are the backbone of the city, the gentry are the backbone of the yeomanry. Depending on the mood of the day they can align either with rich landowners or with their poorer neighbours, and their role at times of social division is often decisive – especially as they make up the backbone of the citizen militia.

A few highly skilled specialist artisans may be included in this category – the best doctors, poets, sculptors, engineers and teachers. These people may well come from a wealthy background, but perhaps they have not been

lucky enough to inherit and have made their own way by their talents.

The Rich

The purpose of wealth is to be freed from the need to work and use leisure to pursue the good life. This may mean indulgent rounds of decadent feasting but is generally agreed to require doing something useful for the community and one's own self-worth like practising law, literature, politics or war, unhindered by the need to spend time on base concerns like industry and commerce. Managing a large estate worked by slaves through a steward will generate significantly more income than renting your land out to tenants, but that approach demands a good supply of slaves or other unfree labour, and also fails to deliver the important benefit of tenant farmers who owe you loyalty and service in addition to rent. In general the more freedom, land ownership and economic self-sufficiency is enjoyed by ordinary citizens, the less inclined they are to do what the upper classes ask of them and the more the rich turn to slave labour. Patronage is an important way for rich folk to spread their influence and for the poor to get by, and a large part of how politics are done.

Most public works are paid for not from the public purse but by the rich, directly from their own resources. This is sometimes voluntary, it can be highly regulated as a burden that gets passed around among the rich from year to year. An aristocrat who pays for construction of a temple or market-place, or to outfit a warship, or for a public entertainment or religious festival, gets to show how much richer and public-spirited he is than his peers. His generosity is a means of competing for the loyalty and votes of ordinary citizens.

In classical Athens an income of 500 Attic *medimnoi* – a large measure of grain equivalent to 6 pecks or 1.5 US bushels - was sufficient to qualify for the highest wealth-class of citizen. 500 Attic *medimnoi* are (more or less) the same

as 3,000 pecks with a value of 3,000 Silver Pieces. In Rome you needed to own property worth 1 million Sestertii (or 250,000 Denarii) to be a Senator, which is equivalent to holding an estate of 250 hectares or more. In some worlds this is of course only entry-level rich and a city of any size will have individuals who have holdings worth many times this amount. The effect of conquest and empire may be to massively increase how rich it is possible to be. Individuals may accumulate holdings running into thousands of Hectares.

Aristocrats and Magnates

Some people manage to get very rich indeed, and (just like everyone else) take care to pass their wealth onto the next generation. An aristocratic household will take care to keep as much of the estate in one piece as it passes to the next generation, as that's how their bloodline – or their family line – stays in the top tier. Aristocracy is not as clearly defined as it is in a medieval society. The word just means 'the best people hold power', and while there are some blood lines involved, or some honour in being descended from famous and accomplished forbears, in a quasi-ancient society people are very aware that *aristocrat* just means 'very rich guy', but mostly *born* rich.

In an Archaic Age, the big aristocrats may actually only have a holding a few times greater than the average. It's words and deeds, shiny armour and maybe a horse that sets him apart – as well as stories about how he's descended from heroes. But by the Imperial Age a magnate might own vast estates – in more than one land, with thousands of slaves and other dependents.

CITY-STATE CULTS AND BROTHERHOODS

Thinking about how Cities are organised and how citizens come together to play their part in the politics, commerce, defence and religion of the city led me to the conclusion that pressing

Mythras rules for Cults and Brotherhoods (CRB p.192ff) into service would be a really appropriate way, and a useful shorthand, to describe city constitutions and Player and Non-Player Character's roles as citizens.

Every city's constitution is unique, but they all follow the same basic structure. After all a city has rules of membership to the citizen body, different ranks within it, and transcends the basic community association that's happening at family and household level. The major difference is in how people move between ranks. For example, if the Common Members of a City-State include all those who are in some way protected by the law (both citizens and metic), or who are born of citizen parents; Dedicated Members are the adult sons and daughters of full citizens expected to play their part in public rituals, defence of the city and so forth; Proven Members is made up of Heads of Household who are entitled to vote in the assembly or sit as jurors in the law courts, Overseers are those who are promoted to become members of the city council or senate, or to hold minor official posts, while Leaders are those elected or appointed to the highest office, like Archon or Consul. The qualifications for each stage may lay more in wealth or in age class than in reaching certain skill thresholds, and the selection to a specific rank from among those eligible may well be by public vote. In many constitutions the most senior offices are only appointed for a year, so those at the top of the organisation will keep rotating around.

City Cults

Every city in a quasi-ancient society has its chief, patron deity. Sometimes the city itself is personified as a god or (more usually) a goddess, but if so is rarely the most important in the local pantheon. Most likely one of the more important gods in the pantheon receives special attention, a dedicated local cult and the most impressive temple in the most prominent

location in town. In a fantasy setting, perhaps those cities which share the same patron deity are naturally aligned with one another. Perhaps it's the reverse, where these cities compete for the god's favour. There are even rituals, known to the Romans as *evocatio*, by which a city could summoned the gods of enemy cities from their temples to re-home them as their own, thus critically weakening the foe and adding to their own magical strength.

A world of independent city-states becomes difficult to imagine if there are major cults where membership cuts across city-state lines. Cults are essentially local to a city, with a few exceptions, including festivals at some major holy site that brings everyone together for a limited time. Cults that do cut across borders need to be specially treated – or will be regarded with serious suspicion, because the adherents are now known to have a loyalty that transcends that of the city-state community. In Roman times many people thought Christianity was a dangerous cult for just this reason. A similar paranoia surrounded the Bacchic cult which was suppressed in Italy in the 2nd Century BCE. But this can also be turned to an advantage if there is a regional power or empire behind the cult – such as Christianity in the later Roman Empire, and before that, the cult of Emperor Worship. We see examples of a paramount or hegemonic power getting to identify local deities with their own and so in some way absorb them. So a goddess that's unique to one city may be revealed to be just an aspect of a goddess much more widely known and worshipped.

In *Shores of Korantia* (p83ff) each city-state has its own set of cults even if they are worshipping the same gods as other cities. Membership of the cult of the ruler-god Anayo in one city does not confer membership of the cult of Anayo in another, In each case the cult of a city-goddess, an aspect of Orayna, the mighty Queen of Heaven, is at the heart of the system. Citizenship requires membership in the city-goddess' cult, but citizens need to enrol in



other cults as well as part of their civic obligations and in support of the role they play in society. So members of a city council may be initiated into the rites of Anayo, and those who serve in the militia may be initiated into the cult of Torthil, and those who sail the oceans into the cult of Pyrolus. The book provides write-ups for key cults of the Korantine city of Vestrikina to provide examples of how cult memberships and citizenship are woven together.

CITY FACTIONS

A city-state can be imagined as a co-operative extended family of more or less homogenous people held together by shared traditions, culture and values. But the reality is usually very different, with intense factionalism, rivalries and frequent bloodshed. Even those cities that manage to maintain a sense of harmony have to deal with a changing world, and change always happens more painfully for some than for others.

Factionalism and division has the potential to spill over into serious violence. History suggests that even in close-knit city-state

worlds people can be all too willing to murder, massacre or execute their fellow citizens.

These internal struggles – often encouraged by foreign rivals – provide plenty of scope for peril, intrigue, plot and drama.

A Conflict of the Orders

This is the age-old class struggle between people who are all free citizens but where the dominance of a wealthy minority has got out of hand and the majority try to wrest back more control of how the city is run. Seeing justice handed out evenly, getting access to important offices of state, a voice at assembly when key decisions are made, redistribution of land, cancellation of debts, and shifting how the burdens and rewards are shared out are all common motivations.

Faction and Patronage

Electioneering politics can get really brutal. Bribery and corruption is routine. The rewards of office, whether in terms of riches or just power and respect, are enough to set rival politicians and their networks of allied and supporters at each others' throats. Some might use very underhand tactics to get an enemy exiled, imprisoned or just humiliated. The more powerful a city, especially an imperial city, the greater the potential rewards of securing a position as a general, government minister or provincial governor, and the more deadly the contest becomes. Conflict between rival candidates' followers and supporters can spill onto the streets, ending in violence and death. Some contenders for political power, especially those who know they can't win in a fair election, arm their supporters and go to civil war.

Religious Clashes

There can be conflict between rival cults who claim their god should be the city's chief deity – or even that there should be no other god but theirs. Any cult that meets in private that

doesn't have a long-established pedigree as part of local customs and culture is suspicious, especially ones that allow membership to non-citizens, even slaves. These are parallel networks and power structures that cut across the normal social structure of household and state. In a fantasy-setting it may be the gods themselves who quarrel over who should have the finest temple, or perhaps for some reason one god bears a grudge against a particular city while another attempts to protect it from harm.

Aristocratic Coup-D'Etats

The rich really believe they are the best people to be in charge, and that they can do everyone (including themselves) a favour if they are firmly in control. They are liberated by their wealth to see things clearly and know what is right, and freed of the need to labour so they can devote time to learning, culture, public speaking – and of course character-building stuff like hunting and war. When frustrated by the inability of the common herd to recognise their innate gifts and virtues, some aristocrats have been known to stage a coup d'etat and replace whatever governing system is in place with something more to their liking. This will usually mean excluding a lot of people from the ability to participate in politics.

An oligarchy, in which all power is concentrated in the hands of a small elite - whether that's a few or a few hundred - is a common outcome of an aristocratic takeover. But if the coup leader can command a big popular following they may be able to set themselves up as an autocrat and un-needed rival aristos who don't fall into line get the chop. Nevertheless some of these people are not entirely self-serving, and a can be genuinely motivated by a sense of public duty. A coup can lead to a reorganisation of the city on a better or fairer footing, its leader then withdrawing from public life to let everyone else get on with things. The histories of city states usually include some famous names of wealthy



aristocrats who have used their power for the good of all the citizens.

Someone's to Blame

A good disaster always has potential to get people angry and looking for scapegoats – whether that's a lost war, a great fire that destroys large swathes of the city, or a plague sweeping through the population. The widespread suffering and loss focuses minds on looking for someone to blame – and failing that, an appropriate scapegoat. It could be a political leader or faction, it could be an immigrant community, or a new-fangled cult that has taken root in the city. Or any combination of these. Bloodshed can be an all too easy solution to problems that seem to be beyond ones control.

Foreign Agents

City states often come into conflict, but it isn't always all out war – at least not to begin with. One city might encourage rebellion or a coup-d'etat in another, or lend assistance to specific factions in the hope that regime change brings about a more friendly – or compliant rival. They can give sanctuary to exiled leaders, and might go so far as to send troops to swing the balance in an internal dispute, or put the 'rightful' rulers back in place when they have been ousted.

Unsporting Competition

In a quasi-ancient world people can get very serious about their sports. Violence between supporters of rival chariot-racing teams, or just between those who get over-excited watching blood sports in the arena, can spill out of the stadium and into the streets. In Constantinople tens of thousands are said to have been killed in the horrific violence following a clash between supporters of the 'blues' and 'greens' racing factions, who had evolved into political and religious camps around their favourite racing colours.

Coming Soon...

In the final part of Korantine Rites, we'll look at how Mythras-style magic changes some of the basic certainties – and uncertainties of life in a fantasy version of a quasi-ancient society. And how Adventurers can try and scratch a living from the soil as they invest their loot in land and estates in the hope of putting their feet up for a peaceful retirement....